audience at court that any of the Barakzai khans who had fled and left their homes would be pardoned on their return to Kabul, and their possessions restored to them: several, such as Nawab Zaman Khan Barakzai with his sons and brothers and with all their dependants and tribesmen, took advantage of the offer of reconciliation, and were restored to their former positions.[14]

Meanwhile, the British troops and sepoys wandered happily around the autumnal palace gardens and the Kabul orchards heavy with fruit, while ‘parties rode hither and thither to visit such objects of curiosity as were described to them’.[15] The city that the British had just seized from Dost Mohammad was then at the peak of its prosperity and with a population of around seventy thousand was by 1839 probably the greatest commercial entrepôt in Central Asia and the centre of the region’s caravan trade. The security that Dost Mohammad had been able to guarantee in his kingdom and the tolerance he had shown to religious minorities meant that Kabul had become a major centre for Hindu traders from Sindh and especially the Sindhi banking capital of Shikarpur; there were also flourishing communities of Jewish, Georgian and Armenian traders.[16]

The narrow streets gave on to the mud-walled compounds of rich merchants and the townhouses of the landowners and tribal chiefs, though from the streets all that could be seen were grandly carved wooden gateways, the wooden shutters and lattices of the overhanging upper rooms and the tops of the mulberry trees visible above the walls. If the gates opened, however, passers-by could catch glimpses of large courtyards in which trickling fountains were placed in the middle of a raised platform, spread with carpets and bolsters and shaded by fruit trees. Recesses in the arcades would be ornamented with intricate plasterwork. Here, under the trellising, the chiefs would loll during the evenings, smoking pipes and listening to musicians play their rababs or the poets recite the great Persian epics.

Between the great houses stretched miles of bustling brick-built bazaars, arranged by trade, with separate streets for shawl merchants, the sellers of spice and rose water, and the importers of Bukhara silks, Russian tea, Lucknavi indigo, Tartar furs, Chinese porcelain and the celebrated stabbing daggers of Isfahan. ‘The shop windows are open to the ground,’ noted James Rattray, a young officer who would later go on to draw some of the finest sketches of Kabul,